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Construction workers in search of shade in New Delhi. (GETTY IMAGES)

NO PLACE TO REST

India's rising heat is exposing a hidden inequality in urban design — pockets of shade are concentrated in affluent enclaves leaving the masses with no respite from the harsh sun

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Menaka Raman

For the past few years now, come the third week of May, the throng of tourists that flocks to Landour in Dehradun swells a little more as people gather to catch sight of the region's most famous resident. It is not an actor or a sportsperson they come to see, but a writer. Famously known as the writer on the hill.

In a career that has spanned over seven decades, and resulted in more than 500 short stories, essays, and novels, which include 70 books for children, Ruskin Bond occupies a space on the Indian literary landscape that few can lay claim to.

"His appeal is universal," says independent bookseller Randhir Arora of Book World, Dehradun. "He has loyal readers between the ages of five and 95, a breadth I am yet to see in any other author."

I won't lie. Since becoming a children's book author myself a few years ago, I have watched the rather marvellous fuss made over Bond on his birthday – and otherwise – with just the teensiest glimmer of envy. What is it like to have entire shelves in book stores dedicated to just your books? To be an unassailable fixture at the top of the 'kidlit' bestseller list? To be

What is it like to be one of India's most beloved writers? A children's author travels to Landour in search of answers

BOND RUSKIN BOND



so beloved by your readers, that they gather near your home to get a glimpse of you? So, when I find myself invited to the launch of the Ruskin Bond Festival in late May – barely a week after the author's 92nd birthday on May 19 – I say yes. I want a ringside view of the celebrations I'd looked at from afar, and if I'm being honest, I harbour hopes that some of the author's literary fairy dust might rub off on me.

Back to simpler times
An initiative of the Ruskin Bond Foundation, the event at Lekhak Gaon, a writers' retreat in Dehradun, includes the screening of an original film from StoneX Global's Mastery series featuring the author, a panel discussion on writing, and sees former IPS officer Kiran Bedi bring Bond's family on stage for a Q&A session that is a mix of a talk show with gentle interrogation. Later, a marble bust in his likeness is unveiled in the gardens. Despite the author's absence from the proceedings due to his frail health, a considerable crowd has turned up to celebrate him and his writing.

When we speak, Arora mentions the delight young readers exhibit when they meet Bond at events. It presents itself in equal measure amongst the grown-ups who have gathered at the festival.

For Hansika Lohani, a features editor with *Platform* magazine, Bond is an indelible part of childhood summers spent in Landour. "Our school had a lodge in the hills, and we would pass Mr. Bond's cottage as we walked up to it. We read his books in school and for us he was a star! We would shout out his name as we crossed his home and he would come out and wave to us from a window," she tells me.

I believe that the books we read as children are more firmly embedded within us than those we read as adults. After all, they play an important but often overlooked role in shaping how we view the world.

I remember the first Ruskin Bond book I ever read. For a child who existed on a diet of Roald Dahl, Richmal Crompton and Enid Blyton, *The Blue Umbrella* was my maiden journey into the hills of India. My own son, now 18,

vividly remembers having *Tigers for Dinner: Tall Tales by Jim Corbett's Khansama* read to him at bedtime.

There is an enduring and timeless quality to Bond's writing, so that even when we read stories set in the '60s or '70s, we feel a tug of the familiar. It's why Shankh Dutt Jha, a 15-year-old student in Bengaluru, loves *The Whistling School Boy*, a compilation of Bond's school stories. "I read the book when I was seven and the stories were so relatable and easy to connect with," he tells me. "Isn't school more or less the same for everyone? We all have to learn maths and science, we have fun and get into trouble."

Sudeshna Shome Ghosh, Executive Publisher at Speaking Tiger, believes that for many readers who have grown up reading Bond, he brings the comfort of familiarity. "His gentle, sometimes gently wicked voice, his eye for the natural world, which we are slowly moving further and further away from, the humour, and the simple yet beautiful language keep drawing readers in. To read him is to know and be a part of a simpler time, something that I am sure appeals to many readers in these fractured and hectic times," she says of the author she has spent close to two decades working with.

Following the blue umbrella
After the inaugural festivities are done, some of us gather for a small, private dinner on the lawns of the gorgeous heritage property the family has moved into to ensure Bond's medical team is easily accessible. When the guest of honour is brought out to meet us, he graciously sits and listens to our tuneless rendition of 'Happy Birthday', before saying a few words.

I can't help but wonder if it takes a toll to share oneself like this with strangers. Especially, a writer who has sought solitude in the hills for so much of his life. Perhaps, it's not as fun as it looks on Instagram. But when I voice my thoughts to those around me, they counter that perhaps he enjoys the company and the interest in him and his life's work even at this age.

It is a tremendous achievement to have statues of oneself unveiled and literature festivals in one's name. But for me, Bond's real legacy – and I think the legacy most meaningful to children's book authors – is the privilege to have been a part of a child's life for some time, no matter how fleeting. And in Bond's cause, it is not fleeting at all. We meet him as children and he stays with us well into adulthood.

When it's my turn to go and meet him, it is close to 11 p.m. Bond sits up in bed, tucked under blankets, patiently answering a journalist's questions about whether he still drinks or not! I shamelessly eavesdrop, feeling sorry he is being kept up so late for these questions. I don't have the heart to keep him up any longer, so I put my questions away and thank him instead on behalf of the nine-year-old reader I once was, who took no small delight in the image of a blue umbrella gently making its way through the hills of Garhwal.

The writer is a children's book author and columnist based in Bengaluru.



Lily King
(WINKY LEWIS)

IN CONVERSATION

Author Lily King on writing about first love and heartbreak in her Women's Prize-shortlisted novel *Heart the Lover*

The moments that stayed

Saurabh Sharma

Reading about love, heartbreak, and simply carrying on with life through Lily King's prose is a novel experience. Her latest novel, *Heart the Lover* (Canongate Books), shortlisted for the 2026 Women's Prize, is billed both as a prequel and sequel to her previous work, *Writers & Lovers* (2020).

The singular voice of the narrator is striking. The way King mines the intellectual underpinnings of the narrator's experiences in her final year of college – falling in and out of love and pursuing a rewarding friendship – is remarkable. Of first loves or otherwise, this is truly a story about a lover, who, despite a broken heart, manages to persevere. Edited excerpts from a conversation with King:

Question: Was it a conscious choice, or did it emerge organically, to make such an intellectually rich story a pleasurable read?

Answer: Everything in my work, except for a vague idea of a few characters and a possible source of tension, happens organically, as I am writing. I could never set out to make something pleasurable for the reader – I feel like that is out of my control, what the reader feels. But I did know that Jordan [the narrator] would be meeting two guys who were more intellectually ambitious than any other students she'd meet at the university, and that her interactions with them would alter the course of her life in many ways. I also knew that I wanted to write about a big first love and a big first heartbreak. I find both those plot lines very pleasurable, but there's no guarantee the reader will.

Q: As a writer, do you feel you are truly in control of your characters?

A: I often compare writing a novel to dreaming about a house. At the start, you walk up the path and through the door and there is the living room, the kitchen, the staircase, the bedrooms. You come back down and suddenly someone shoves you down into the basement and locks the door. That's how I always feel two-thirds of the way through a first draft. In the basement with a locked door. Each novel is its own puzzle and the only useful thing about having written one previously is that you know you can get out of the basement.

Endings for me are either really easy

or really hard. For *Heart the Lover*, it was hard. I wrote 35 pages set in Iceland at the end of one draft. Disaster. Tried again. And again. Twelve days before the book went into production, I landed the real ending.

I feel like it is a partnership between me and my characters. I am not fully in control, nor are they. We prod each other forward.

Q: How important was it for you to tell Cyra's story in *Heart the Lover*?

A: I couldn't imagine writing the first section without Cyra, because if I am to write about the lives of young women, rape and murder are a part of it, tangentially or up close, even in a cloistered, elite environment like a university. We all have these stories. We all have our Cyras. And often, like the narrator, we grieve and process them alone, and not sufficiently. The first part of this book is about entanglements with men. When women engage with men, there are great joys and great perils. That is the way it is in our world. I needed to write about that range of experiences.

Q: As a writer, how do your experiences and experiential memory inform your art?

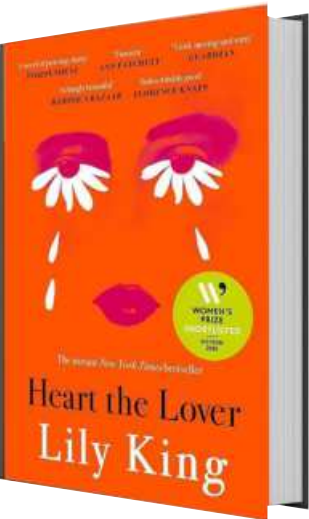
A: As I go about my life, I am not thinking of making what I am experiencing into art. There isn't some writer in me trying to convert it in real time. My mind works slower than that, and years have to go by before I realise I want to write about some emotion I had in a particular situation. But once I have written about something that I lived

in some way, the real memory and the fictional situation sort of fuse in my head and can become hard to separate.

Q: Your two essays for *Vogue*, written five years apart, are very much in conjunction with this novel. Your thoughts?

A: Yes, the essays are about the two big loves of my youth. They both died in 2019, a month apart, in separate hospitals in different cities. Less than a year later, we were in COVID-induced lockdown, and death and illness were all around. I think all that informed this book and the arc of this book – what love feels like when you're young and how it feels to lose people you loved and lost and regained and lost again.

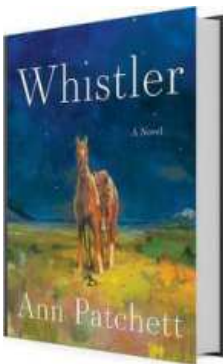
The interviewer is a Delhi-based queer writer and culture critic.



BROWSER

Whistler
Ann Patchett
Bloomsbury
₹699

"Where does all the love go when a person dies? Where does their voice go?" The Pulitzer-nominated author channels the voice of a beloved departed friend in this story about a woman and her stepfather who reconnect after years of estrangement.



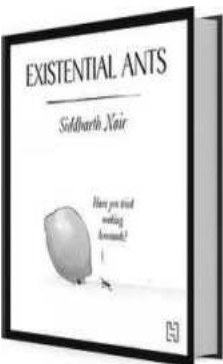
All That's Left Behind
Aditya Tiwari
Simon & Schuster
₹399

Through vivid imagery and intimate socio-political recollections, this collection of 66 poems explores themes ranging from memory and displacement to love and resistance. The poet, a queer-rights activist, previously hosted the BBC's *Voices* series on men's mental health.



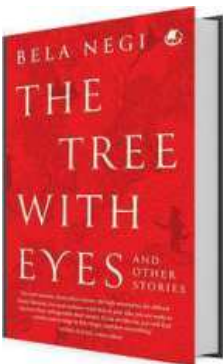
Existential Ants
Siddharth Nair
Hachette India
₹599

Ants, cats, penguins, crows and other animals dispense wisdom with a mix of wit and satire in this illustrated comic book about what makes us human. The author began experimenting with ink-and-watercolour sketches, several of which are included in this book, during the lockdown.



The Tree With Eyes and Other Stories
Bela Negi
Tranquebar
₹499

In this debut fiction, the author and filmmaker examines the changing lives of Uttarakhand's mountain communities. Through nine stories, she explores the consequences of migration and ecological change on vulnerable people and ecosystems.



Born into privilege, lived in revolt

Mallu Swarajyam's memoir is a valuable oral record, though its stream-of-consciousness style can sometimes feel breathless

Ramya Kannan
ramya.kannan@thehindu.co.in

If there was ever a book that is of women, for women, and by women, it is this. Mallu Swarajyam's memoir, *The Fire of Defiance*, was orally narrated to three women – feminist historian Uma Chakravarti, women's rights activist Vimala Morthala, and Telugu writer S. Katayayini. Translated by Purnima Tammireddy, this book ticks all those boxes.

One of India's most extraordinary revolutionaries, Swarajyam, already immortalised in P. Sainath's book, *The Last Heroes*, now tells her tale her own way. She recalls a life lived amid the forests and the poorest of people, driving change and revolt in Telangana. The image of the rifle-toting woman has become emblematic of the early struggles in the region, and the political and cultural renaissance that she and women like her ushered into a modern India.

Even more striking than the image of the woman with the gun is the stunning image of an 11-year-old Swarajyam, standing arms akimbo in defiance of the oppressive *zamindari* system and her uncle, insisting that foodgrains be distributed to bonded labourers of different castes. This kind of revolutionary thought cannot be implanted; it is organic. Clearly, this was a child born to lead change, to drag it kicking and screaming, to deliver justice to labourers.

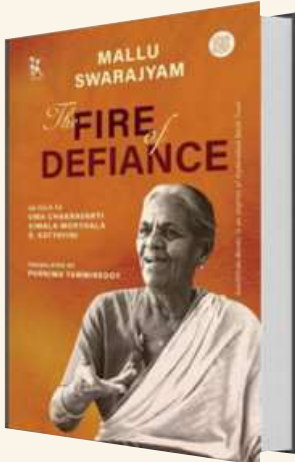
Taking the tough road
Born into a landlord family herself, it would have been easy for Swarajyam to sink into the relative luxury that the privilege of birth afforded her. But she took the tough road, fighting for the people, living in penury, and struggling with back-breaking labour to eke out a hand-to-mouth existence.

That is the life of revolutionaries: the change they seek for the people is possible, but for themselves, change in living circumstances is a long and arduous journey.

The book tells us that she joined the Communist Party at age 16, inspired by several close family members. A fiery orator and fearless rebel, she quickly rose to become a commander of an armed *dalam*, or fighting unit, in the Telengana rebellion against the dominion of the Nizam, and the atrocities perpetrated by the police and landed gentry. Interestingly,

this is not just Swarajyam's story, but the story of hundreds of comrades, both men and women, who sacrificed their lives, babies, and familial wealth in order to fight for the rights of the people. In fact, Swarajyam remains the protagonist as the book hums with voices, always surrounding her, establishing context, filling up the silences, and providing depth and energy.

Critic of zamindari
As an oral record, it comes with a near stream-of-consciousness approach, where the events or people are intimate and orderly to Swarajyam, and yet, to us, represent a breathless narrative where events and people can



Mallu Swarajyam:
The Fire of Defiance
As told to Uma Chakravarti, Vimala Morthala and S. Katayayini; trs Purnima Tammireddy
Zubaan Publishers and SouthSide Books
₹450

sometimes become a blur. While recording an oral narrative as it is being spoken has definite value, some reordering could make things clearer for readers far removed from the actual struggle itself. Swarajyam did not merely ensue *gram raj* in 3,000 villages in the region. A constant critic of the *zamindari* system, she confiscated nearly one million acres of land and redistributed it to the landless. A revolutionary consciousness, once formed, seldom departs. As an MLA from 1978 to 1984, she spoke up in the Assembly for women's issues, and served on committees granting property rights for women. She also served in the All India Democratic Women's Association's Andhra Pradesh unit for close to three decades. She set new goals for us, with her inspiring dedication to equity and justice, and her constant revolutionary zeal.



Mallu Swarajyam (left) at a public meeting in Nalgonda, Telangana, 2006. (NAGARA GOPALA)



INTERVIEW

'NOW IS THE TIME TO RECLAIM THE CONSTITUTION'

Senior advocate Indira Jaising on writing her memoir, women's rights, and the challenges facing the judiciary

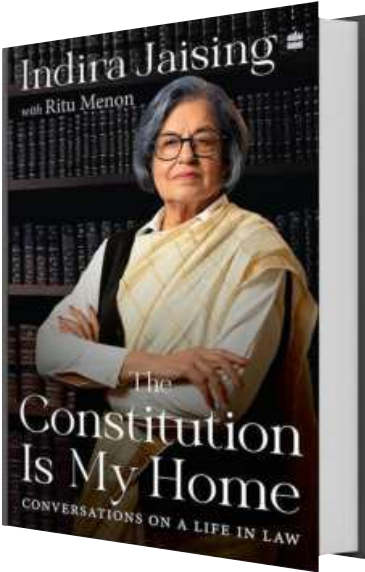
Constitution is increasingly being weaponised?

A: Yes, we are seeing the weaponisation of the Constitution. But that is also why I have come to regard the Constitution as my home. The Constitution was not written for governments or ruling parties; it was written for the people. Now is the time to reclaim the Constitution, abide by it, and reside in it.

Q: You write about your mother having to sacrifice her agency and personal freedom after marriage. Do you still see marriage as a patriarchal institution?

A: I do. We have recently seen the dowry-related deaths of so-called modern women. Marriage continues, in many ways, to be a form of property exchange.

In this country, we seem to honour women when they die, not when they are alive. I have seen countless cases where women approach courts seeking justice, only to be met with the accusation that they are misusing the law. How do you know she is misusing the law? Have you looked inside her home? The matrimonial home is still regarded as a 'man's castle' and is far from being a safe space for women. Women must have



access to a violence-free environment within their homes. It was this gap in the law that led me to imagine legislation such as the Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act, 2005. The law has, to a large extent, helped women gain a greater sense of security within the home. But what is ultimately needed is a change in social attitudes. Patriarchy continues to shape our social institutions.

Q: Do you believe patriarchal conditioning continues to influence judicial thinking?

A: Yes, patriarchal thinking definitely permeates the judicial system. At the same time, I believe such attitudes can be challenged through advocacy. There has also been a growing recognition of the role that legal language plays in stereotyping women. During the tenure of former Chief Justice of India D.Y. Chandrachud, a legal glossary was published to guide judges against the

Trailblazer In 2009, Indira Jaising became the first woman to be appointed the Additional Solicitor General of India. (SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR)

use of inappropriate gendered terms in legal discourse.

Q: You launched *The Lawyers* magazine in the 1980s because you felt contempt powers were being used to silence criticism. How do you view the recent rise in contempt proceedings? Should such powers be reserved only for cases involving a direct interference with the administration of justice?

A: Yes, I agree with your latter observation. Where there is a direct interference with the administration of justice, the invocation of contempt powers may be justified.

At the end of the day, the judiciary has to earn its reputation. It must demonstrate not only its legality but also its legitimacy. Most importantly, it has to earn the trust of the public. Contempt of court is not the way to earn that trust.

Q: While the Constitution protects the freedom of religion, how should courts approach cases where religious practices appear to be at odds with fundamental rights?

A: The conflict is irreconcilable. But the problem is a legacy of colonialism. In 1772, the British decided that Hindus would be governed by Hindu law, Muslims by Muslim law, and so on. There is no Constitutional rationale for continuing to organise personal laws in such silos. As a result, discriminatory practices persist across all personal laws. When they remain unaddressed, you realise that the power of religion and other non-state actors can extend beyond the power of the Constitution. That is simply not acceptable.

Q: Following the expansion of the Supreme Court's sanctioned strength, four High Court Chief Justices and one woman senior advocate have been appointed to the top court. Do you see this as a missed opportunity?

A: At the time the Collegium made its recommendations, three women were serving as Chief Justices of High Courts, with a fourth was set to join their ranks. Given this pool of senior women judges, I had hoped that more women would be elevated to the Supreme Court. However, not all the vacancies have been filled, and I remain hopeful that greater attention will be paid to gender representation in future appointments.

Q: You write about how your opposition to the bail pleas of certain officials implicated in the Gujarat riots was followed by the cancellation of the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) registration of Lawyers Collective, the organisation you co-founded. What message would you have for young lawyers who feel disillusioned by the profession?

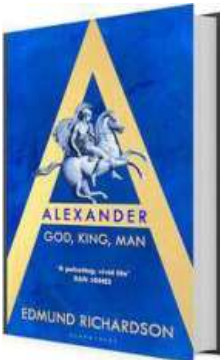
A: I have always felt that those proceedings were, unfortunately, linked to my speaking out about the sexual harassment complaint made by a Supreme Court staff member against the then Chief Justice of India, Ranjan Gogoi, and the manner in which the matter was handled. What hurt was not the loss of the FCRA registration itself; it was feeling attacked by an institution that I had served all my life. However, what helped us through that difficult period was the fact that we were practising professionals. That is the message I would give young lawyers. The legal profession is a powerful and independent profession. Young lawyers must recognise their own strength. So long as they remain independent and continue working in the interests of the most vulnerable and disenfranchised, they have nothing to fear.

Scan the QR code to watch Indira Jaising in conversation on magazine.thehindu.com

Alexander: God, King, Man

Edmund Richardson
Bloomsbury
₹799

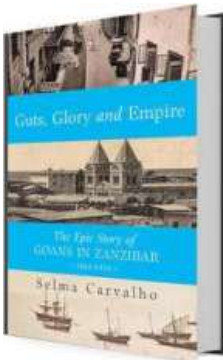
Historian Richardson has translated source material from 12 ancient languages. He has done a decade of research, which has taken him from catacombs in Egypt to the passes in Afghanistan. This biography also includes a series of important new discoveries.



Guts, Glory and Empire

Selma Carvalho
Speaking Tiger
₹999

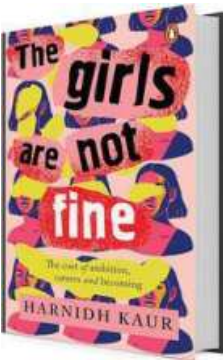
Set against the backdrop of Europe's ascendancy in Africa, this work of history chronicles the lives of Goan settlers in Zanzibar and restores South Asian voices to Indian Ocean histories. Carvalho is a British-Asian writer whose work explores themes of migration, memory and belonging.



The Girls Are Not Fine

Harnidh Kaur
Penguin
₹499

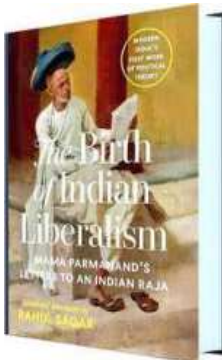
This book explores the world of women's invisible labour, the emotional calculations they make daily, and the ways in which they learn to fit into rooms that were never built for them. Kaur, who has served as Head of Fund at WTFund, is a funder and cultural critic.

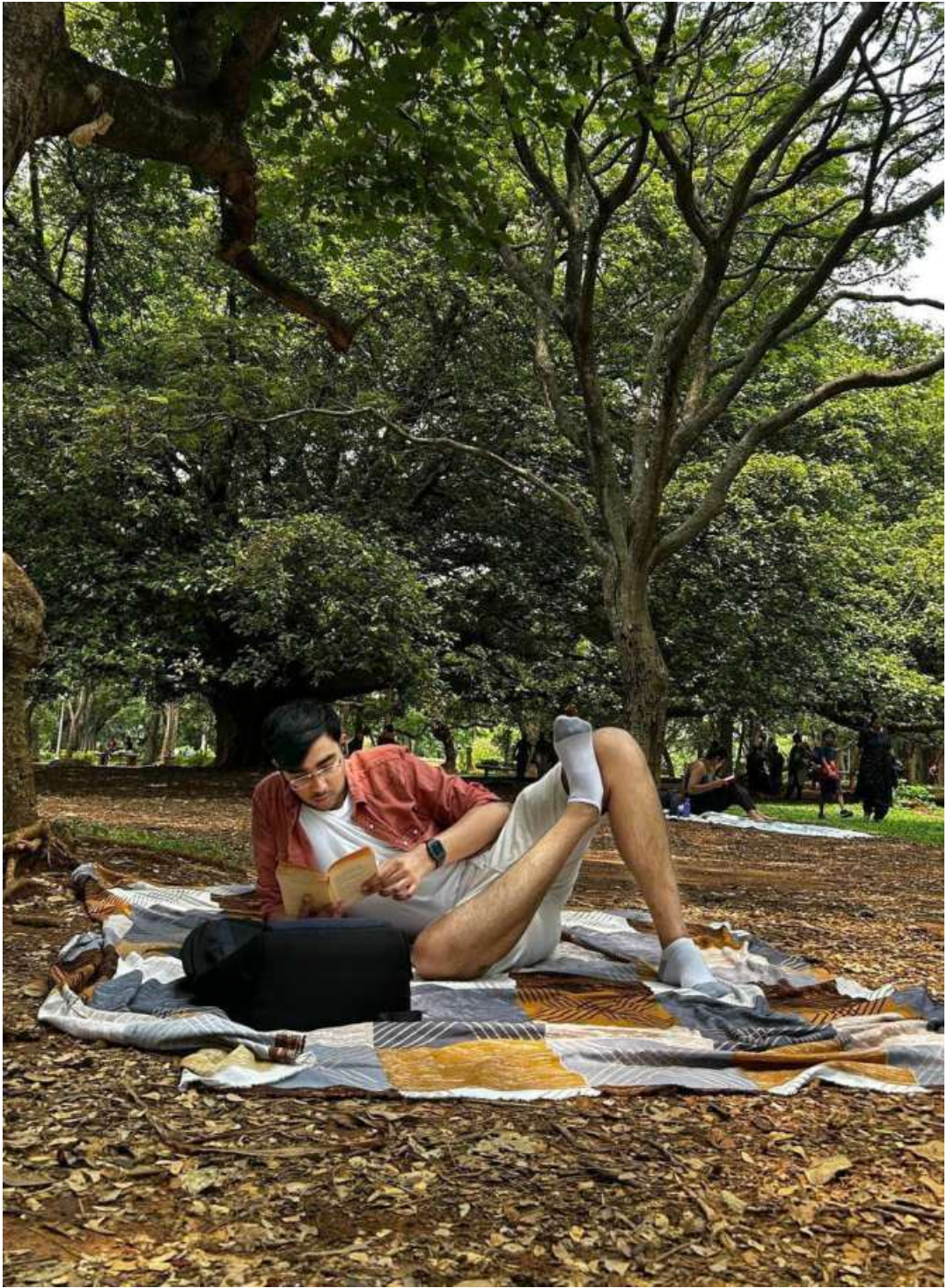


The Birth of Indian Liberalism

Rahul Sagar
Juggernaut
₹899

First published in 1891, this is the earliest work of political theory written and published in modern India. Sagar, a political theorist, restores Mama Parmanand's letters to an Indian Raja. His introduction reconstructs the social reformer's life, ideas and political world.





A member of Cubbon Reads, Bengaluru; and (far left) gig workers taking a break in Kolkata. (CUBBON READS AND GETTY IMAGES)

"Anyone who doesn't have a good house or place to rest should be able to find open, accessible spaces outside without spending money." Nationally, Articles 19 and 21 of the Indian Constitution protect freedoms and life (Article 19 promises six democratic freedoms: of speech, assembly, association, movement, residence and profession, while Article 21 guarantees the right to life, dignity and personal liberty). But most people are unaware of them.

The cost of staying cool Prema Kumari works as a cook for several families in North Bengaluru's gated communities. The 53-year-old makes three meals a day in four kitchens. Her job begins at 6.30 a.m. and ends by 7 p.m. "I am not allowed to even sit on the benches in the society's gardens," she tells me, about the moments of rest she gets in between. "The security guards shoo us [domestic workers]

The World Health Organisation prescribes a minimum of 9 sq.m. of green space per capita in urban areas, but cities like Chennai and Pune have just 0.81 sq.m. and 1.4 sq.m., respectively. Bengaluru offers roughly 2.25 sq.m., and Mumbai 1.24 sq.m.



Gig and domestic workers, and people who have to be in the public arena have no place to rest. In the afternoon, some parks in the city are locked

AVANI CHOKSHI Labour lawyer

away. If we want to sit down, we must go sit outside the society." With no benches under the trees outside, Kumari goes down to the stuffy basement, where she has made friends with the laundry woman.

In their seminal book, *Why Loiter? Women & Risk on Mumbai Streets* (2011), journalist Sameera Khan, sociologist Shilpa Phadke and archaeologist Shilpa Ranade ask why citizens should not find pleasure in their city spaces. And, more importantly, who has access to these spaces? "If women, marginalised groups, so-called 'outsiders' or the working class population have no access to a space, then it hints at what kind of a person is an acceptable citizen in society," Khan says over a phone call.

The book finds that urban planning is patriarchal in nature, and designed almost always with an able-bodied, middle or upper-class, upper caste, cis-het man in mind. Anyone who doesn't fit this

description just has to make do with the infrastructure they get. "We want the labour of working class people, but not their presence in the spaces that surround us," she adds.

Loss of democratic experiences India's metro cities are constantly in a state of work-in-progress: consumed by the never-ending construction of skyscrapers, Metro lines, roads, and newer extensions. For instance, in Chennai, Metro Rail work has been ongoing for over 17 years, in various parts of the city. Things are not too different in Mumbai and Bengaluru; in the latter, the work's moving at a snail's pace, averaging just 7 km per year.

Parks, maidans, beaches, footpaths, public libraries and even neighbourhood markets – once a testament to India's democratic nature – are quickly disappearing. Their patrons are policed, surveilled or pushed towards private-public spaces such as malls that welcome them only as consumers. As gated communities and private experiences multiply, truly public spaces are at risk. The erosion of such spaces directly results in the loss of non-curved, mixed-class, unfiltered encounters.

"A free public park does not ask who you are before letting you in. It naturally allows for a mix of classes, languages and backgrounds," says Shruti Sah, who started the initiative Cubbon Reads in 2022 with her



Lessons from Kochi and Jaipur

As temperatures rise, cities such as Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Pune and Hyderabad are taking small steps. In the Pink City, a solar-powered cooling station offers 5°-6° C relief to pedestrians and workers. In Chennai, airconditioned rest lounges (in pic) have been opened for gig workers. In Kochi, 'Kavaki', a community-led urban greening movement launched in 2021, has created several recreational green spaces by planting native tree saplings. "Kavaki flipped the script on conservation by making neighbourhood stakeholders the primary custodians," says Priya Narayanan, senior programme manager–urban development, WRI (World Resources Institute) India, who was involved in its planning. "This started with Mapathons [mapping events to identify suitable spaces for urban micro-forests]."

NO PLACE TO REST

Pooja Salvi

Trees can cool neighbourhoods by between 2°C and 12°C. And though Noida, just under 50 km from New Delhi, may boast 726 parks and 800 kilometres of green belt, its cooling infrastructure is unevenly distributed. The city's pockets of shade and greenery are often concentrated in affluent enclaves, far from the dark stores, construction sites and arterial roads where gig workers spend much of their day.

Take Shajid, a gig worker who makes delivery runs in Greater Noida's Patwari. His service platform's 10-minute

guarantees see him racing against the clock, shuttling between Blinkit dark stores and delivery destinations on his two-wheeler, pushing through traffic, speeding or breaking red lights, all under the harsh Noida sun – where temperatures can reach a staggering 46°C. For workers like him, relief is fleeting: a few minutes in the air-conditioned towers while waiting for an elevator.

Cities without shelter

The Patwari locality of Greater Noida is a fast developing area with large apartment complexes, some with 30-plus towers that house thousands. People pay crores of rupees to

secure their place in these gated communities and apartment complexes with manicured gardens, meticulously maintained parks, walkways and clubhouses. As welcoming as these private-public spaces are for the residents, they are cordoned off to others. So, what about the workers who toil for hours in these sprawling houses? Where is their access to leisure and rest?

Unfortunately, this story is playing out across the country. Avani Chokshi, a labour lawyer from Bengaluru, says urban planning has been hostile to common people. "Gig and domestic workers, and people who have to be in the public arena have no place to rest,"

she states. "In the afternoon, some local parks in the city [Koramangala's Lakshmi Devi Park, Citizen Park in R.T. Nagar, and many others] are locked; they open only during the early morning hours and evenings." If you ask a guard, they'll tell you it is to keep "nuisance and illegal activities" at bay.

In reality, such closures hinder The Karnataka Parks, Play-fields and Open Spaces (Preservation and Regulation) Act, 1985. The State legislation is designed to protect, manage and regulate green spaces, recreational areas, and open lands within urban areas. Recently, when a citizen tried

to raise this issue on Bengaluru's civic grievance app, Sahaaya 2.0, it was updated stating, "Park will be open morning at 5AM to 11AM and evening 4PM to 8PM. Resolved complaint." The irony was clearly lost on them. "One has the right to be in a public space," adds Chokshi.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



More than a million people transit between Chhatrapati Shivaji and Churchgate every day. But the access routes to the stations are disrupted. Pavements are dug up haphazardly or are encroached. More than a million people have to tackle dangerous hurdles to get to work

ATUL KUMAR Founder-trustee, Art Deco Mumbai Trust

Pooja Salvi

Hawkers are being removed from streets across India. This can be counterproductive on many fronts. "With activities [like hawkers], there's vigilance that is not [related to] police presence," explains Vidya Tongbram, an architect from New Delhi, who worked on the Chandni Chowk redevelopment project. "It actually makes the environment safer rather than having a sterile space."

In the search for clean aesthetics, infrastructure development in India is stripping cities of their unique identities, and their masses. "The way we design these modern, monstrous cities... is clearly drawn through lines of who belongs and who doesn't," says journalist and writer Sameera Khan. "The marginalised and working class are kept away from them."

One way for citizens to reclaim their city is to occupy as much of it as possible. Whether it is with purpose (commuting, grocery shopping) or leisure (going to a park, reading on a bench). A big hurdle: lack of access.

Everyday struggles

Sushmita Sundaram, 39, a communications consultant from Bengaluru's hip neighbourhood Koramangala, says she would prefer to walk to the *kirana* store at the corner instead of ordering from quick-commerce platforms such as Swiggy Instamart or Blinkit. "If you're lucky enough to find a pavement with no loose stones or other obstructions, it is difficult to access them especially if you are elderly or disabled," she says. Sundaram has a knee injury. "Ironically, [as her doctor advises] the best thing for my knee is to walk, to build resilience," she says. "But



(Clockwise from left) Chandni Chowk redevelopment project; members of Snugbub; and a pavement in Bengaluru. (S. THIRU, I. ALLEN EGENUSE)

TAKE BACK THE STREETS

As cities are built around vehicles, pedestrians are losing ground. Awareness initiatives, citizen-centric design and apps offer hope

that would mean having access to a walkable city. These days, it is assumed that anyone navigating a city will have access to private vehicles." Walkability, as she puts it, is a privilege now.

Virali Modi, 34, is a wheelchair user who recently moved from a "horribly dug-up" Mumbai to Bengaluru. Things didn't improve much. "The biggest adjustment was not venturing out, not living life," she says. "The world is not built to accommodate someone like me. I have the same rights as anybody else, yet my accessibility is not being taken care of."

According to the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPWD) Act, 2016, all public spaces, transportation systems and government services are legally required to be universally accessible, emphasising equality, dignity, and accessibility across all sectors. It's implementation, however, is uneven. Earlier this year, Modi was keen to visit Bengaluru's famous Lalbagh Flower Show. "But as soon as I saw pictures of how crowded it was, how inaccessible



In the last five years alone, India has reportedly built more than 50,000 km of expressways and national highways. These include ring roads, elevated corridors and flyovers across Delhi-NCR, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad. But they come at the cost of pedestrian movement

[with unpaved trails, elevated rocky terrain], I decided to stay home and watch videos of it," she says. "I shouldn't have to make these concessions."

Walk at your own risk

When cities focus on vehicular traffic and not pedestrian activity, citizens find themselves shrinking to the peripheries. In the last five years alone, India has reportedly built more than 50,000 km of expressways and national highways. These include ring roads, elevated corridors and flyovers across Delhi-NCR, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad. But they come at the cost of pedestrian movement.

"India's vision seems to be to reach the No.1 position in global automobile manufacturing and not to create people-centric cities," says A.V. Venugopal, programme manager for Healthy Streets & Partnerships at ITDP (Institute for Transportation and Development Policy), a global organisation that promotes sustainable urban transport solutions. "Naturally, there is an



How do we show citizenship in this country if we can't hang out, be there for social demonstrations, to voice protest, or simply for leisure? These are important aspects of citizenship. If you don't really access your city and its public spaces, you don't access your country

SAMEERA KHAN Co-author of *Why Loiter? Women & Risk on Mumbai Streets*

economic angle to it – setting up industries brings in investments, jobs and an ecosystem of money flow." The drawback is that roads are built prioritising vehicular movement. Pedestrian movement is unaccounted for. Not only does that make walking inadvisable but also dangerous.

Venugopal leads ITDP India's work on street design and travel demand management across Tamil Nadu, while helping scale insights from this work nationally. He has played a central role in conceptualising the Complete Streets Project with the World Bank and Greater Chennai Corporation.

Apps to the rescue

People are now stepping up, too. In Bengaluru, the city's footpaths have long been in disarray – broken, uneven, littered with garbage and debris, and encroached by shops. They recently went viral when a Canadian man shared a reel on social media about how he "attempted to use the footpath from Domlur to Indiranagar" unsuccessfully navigating broken portions and encroachments. It put pressure on the authorities, and within a week, the footpath was repaired.

Citizens realised they should find new ways to hold the government accountable, and a slew of apps was launched. Just last month, a 14-year-old developer launched a civic-tech app called Rasthe, which allows people to flag damaged footpaths, construction-related disruptions, and traffic snarls to the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike (BBMP).

Around the same time, in Juhu, Mumbai, citizens created the 'Keep Juhu Clean' platform, where residents can geo-tag their location and register civic issues such as illegal pavement encroachments, tree cutting, sanitation issues and the like. And in Gurugram, May saw the launch of MCG Haryana – to report sanitation issues and more.

Citizen participation is key if Indians want things to change. Atul Kumar, founder-trustee of the non-profit Art Deco Mumbai Trust, who is a part of several NGOs that actively engage in protecting open spaces and heritage regulations, says that if community groups are absent, the deterioration of spaces would be far more significant. "Citizen participation is a lifeline that keeps some checks and balances in place between what planners and administrators want to do and how citizens question their motivations and outcomes."



Best green cover globally

1. Oslo, Norway, boasts 67% tree coverage, featuring vast protected forests known as Osloomarka, urban parks and sustainability initiatives.

2. Ljubljana, Slovenia, reportedly has over 540 sq.m. of public green space per resident – all open and accessible to the public.

3. Frankfurt, Germany, has 52% green spaces, including inner city gardens such as Frankfurt City Forest (in pic, above), community gardens and protected nature reserves like Schwanheimer Duene and Enkheimer Ried.

4. In Singapore, the 'City in Nature Green Plan' is being implemented to conserve and integrate nature. It boasts about 50% green space that features vertical gardens, micro-habitats, and nature reserves.

5. Vienna, Austria, boasts about 200 sq.km. of green spaces or waterbodies, which is approximately 50% of its land area.



Mercury rising

Last year, a study by the non-profit HeatWave found at least 84 heatstroke deaths recorded across India between March 1 and June 24. It noted that the true toll was likely to be higher due to diagnostic "blind spots". The report, titled *Struck by Heat: A News Analysis of Heatstroke Deaths in India in 2025*, found that Maharashtra reported the highest number of deaths at 17, followed by 15 each in Uttar Pradesh and Telangana.

partner Harsh Snehanthu. "For many, especially those without access to private leisure spaces, parks become essential grounds for pause, movement and presence."

As part of Cubbon Reads, Bengaluru's readers gather every Saturday to read silently. "We have seen migrants who are new to the city, families, students and regulars all occupy the same space without friction," Snehanthu says, adding, "Access to something as simple as sitting on grass now increasingly requires entry into a park. As spaces marketed as 'living in nature' often come at a premium and are tied to privilege."

Demand and defend public spaces According to UN-Habitat, the programme for sustainable urban development, 30% of

city land should be reserved as public open space. Indian cities barely cross 10%. The World Health Organization prescribes a minimum of 9 sq.m. of green space per capita in urban areas, but cities like Chennai and Pune have just 0.81 sq.m. and 1.4 sq.m., respectively. Bengaluru offers approximately 2.25 sq.m., Delhi 2.9 sq.m., and Mumbai 1.24 sq.m.

One of the main concerns Khan and the others have is: citizens are not aware of eroding spaces. As they, unquestioningly, learn to live without parks, lakes, benches and tree-lined footpaths, they are running the risk of losing more such spaces. "If citizens don't actively choose to use public spaces because they don't find them in their vicinities or find them unclear or inaccessible, they won't notice when these spaces disappear or increasingly get privatised [given to builders or private developers]," Khan says. The more people are pushed towards enclosed, privatised spaces, the more the idea of freely occupying a city begins to wear away.

The only way that public spaces can survive is if people demand, use and defend them. Not just in moments of protests – for tree felling or demolished parks – but in everyday life, by recognising that lakes, parks, footpaths and playgrounds are as essential to city infrastructure as highways, flyovers and tunnels. The power is in our hands: whether we want to build cities for consumption and exclusion, or cities that can make room for pause and co-existence.

PREMA KUMARI Cook



The writer is a features journalist exploring culture, people, and urban life.



GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

To, His Excellency Hon. Shri Araghchi-ji, Foreign Minister, Iran

Subject: Permission for 'Chogada Taara' group dance in Strait of Hormuz

Respected sir, first of all, thank you so much for allowing several Indian ships – especially those carrying LPG cylinders – to safely pass through the Strait of Hormuz. On behalf of billions of fellow Indians and their 100% democratically elected government, I express our collective appreciation for your understanding.

I am aware that Your Excellency must be busy with war and stuff. But tell me, sir: have you never wanted to dance like crazy in an exotic location and post the video on social media? My friends in Iran tell me you really like the song 'Kaala Chashma' from the film *Baar Baar Dekho* (2016). Is it true? We also love it. But let me first introduce myself.

My name is Mehul, affectionately known as Mehul-bhai. I am the Chief Convenor, Secretary-General, and Tour Operator of India Abroad Dance Service (IADS). We are in the business of helping Indian tourists (me included) perform group dances in unexpected locations and posting the reels, which then go viral.

You may have seen our recent *garba* dance on the airport tarmac in Vietnam next to a Vietjet Air plane. The video got 10 million views in two days. As a result, millions of people all over the world are booking tickets to this airport, bringing more business, more tourism, and more prosperity to Vietnam. I'm sure you've seen our performance of 'Chhaiyaya Chhaiyaya', chosen specifically for Hanoi's Train Street. We have also performed 'Shahtan ka Sala' at Capitol Hill, Washington, D.C., 'Naatu Naatu' on top of Dubai's Burj Khalifa, and 'Kanjia Poovu Kannala' at 10 Downing Street, London.

ALLEGEDLY Group dance in Hormuz

Application for garba performance in Strait of Hormuz – the only place on Earth untouched by dancing Indians

We have danced on board the Tokyo Metro, in the forests of Amazon, and on the ice fields of Antarctica. There is no place on Earth we haven't lived up with our Bluetooth speakers, except one, and since March, it's become a popular demand: the Strait of Hormuz. Sir, I humbly request for full permission (and full safety) for our small cruise ship to transit for 10 minutes inside the Strait of Hormuz – just long enough for us to do our group dance to the super-hit track 'Chogada Taara' (English translation: I'm your stylish lover) from the 2018 Hindi film *Loveyatri* (or love traveller). It's the all-time favourite of Indians

dancing abroad. I'm sure you're familiar with it. In case you're not, you can learn the steps by watching the video on YouTube, where its view count is 106 million – more than your country's population. Sir, perhaps you are wondering about some negative remarks against us on social media. I can assure you it is all racist nonsense. They are targeting Indians purely out of jealousy because we recently became Vishwaguru. As you are aware, after zero and zero press conferences, Bollywood group dance is India's biggest contribution to world civilisation. Our greatest blockbusters have

songs where the hero, heroine and extras dance in Switzerland, Scotland, and in front of each of the Seven Wonders of the World. It was after watching our film stars' glorious dance performances all over the world that I started IADS.

Today, IADS has grown into a group of 75 eminent tourists who have visited and performed at airports, parking lots, river cruises, and promenades in over 235 countries in the last 12 years – all on an Indian passport. For this achievement, I have been recognised with dozens of awards, including the Order of the Phoenix of the Seven Kingdoms of Westeros, and more recently, the Grand Cross of the Viking Order of Merit, the second highest civilian award of Norway.

I assure you that our ship won't carry anything suspicious – no oil, spies, or any other non-verg items – and we'll maintain safe distance from all security installations. Speaking of security, in the 'Chogada Taara' video, there is a sequence where two policemen join the dance. In case your soldiers are interested, we shall be pleased to accommodate two IRGC officers in our dance group, provided they are in their official uniform.

Another small request: during the dance performance, whenever the refrain *Ore rangila taara* comes, we would like your esteemed navy to shoot a small missile into the sky – not too close to our ship, but close enough so that it comes in the frame in the background. That way, nobody will doubt us when we say we did Bollywood group dance in the Strait of Hormuz.

Thanking you, in anticipation of your kind co-operation,

Mehul-bhai



G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

Raja Muzaffar Bhat knows how to read the fine print. Tender documents are like whodunnits waiting to be unravelled for the 49-year-old environmental activist. Bhat, who built his credibility as a Right to Information (RTI) expert and is now chairman of the J&K Climate Action Group, is the tenth generation of his family to live in Wathora village, 12 km south of Srinagar and home to Kashmir's famous *Bhand Pather* folk theatre.

He adeptly plays ace detective as he scours the legalese for clues ranging from problematic clauses to forgotten environmental/pollution clearances. He can recite sections of existing laws faster than you can say 'Vande Mataram' and he has the skill set required to hold government institutions accountable. The National Green Tribunal (NGT) and the Supreme Court have sided with him in his sustained campaign against illegal riverbed mining in Kashmir.

Bhat was a champion of the RTI movement and helped push through the former State's RTI Act in 2009. The central Act replaced it a decade later, when the special status of Jammu & Kashmir under Article 370 was revoked. The age of RTIs, when Bhat would file 30-50 applications a month and people referred to him as an "information bank" because he ferretted out details ranging from judges' assets to the way

Most of Kashmir's NGT cases in the past six years have been filed by Raja Muzaffar Bhat.

PERSON OF INTEREST

RAJA MUZAFFAR BHAT: GRASSROOTS MAN

The RTI pioneer and environmental activist continues to hold power to account in Kashmir



government schemes were working, has ended. Post-2019, as officials delayed answering RTI queries and a jump in infrastructure and construction projects made Bhat's paradise look ragged, he turned his attention to the strained natural environment.

He still uses the old skills. Just the day before we speak, he filed an RTI application to find out how many Chinara and other specified trees (more rigorously protected by the law) have been cut across 10 districts in the past two to three years. The petition has been filed in the NGT.

Some days he may be fighting for the tawny owls that find solace in the Chinars, a key symbol of Kashmiri heritage. On other days, he is raging about the garbage crisis in rural Kashmir or how the Jal Jeevan Mission, a Modi government promise to provide safe drinking water on tap to all rural Indians, hasn't reached the Chopan. The shepherd community lives near the source of the River Doodhganga – once a milky white, sparkling lifeline for lakhs – yet drink dirty water. "We talk of AI and digital India but when I go to such areas, I see no development," says Bhat. "The marginalised don't get access to welfare schemes."

Fighting a disconnected bureaucracy

Global weather data shows that 95 of the world's 100 hottest cities are in India. Trees and forests are being decimated at an unprecedented rate to build highways and for other urban development. In this scenario, we need more custodians like Bhat, who know how to marry social media advocacy with grassroots relationships and an understanding of premier environmental bodies such as the NGT.

Thanks to Bhat, the NGT issued an order last year directing officials in Srinagar to tackle a sprawling hill made up of 11.5 tonnes of garbage – festering for decades at a landfill in the city – within two years. The cabinet has approved ₹361 crore to fix the problem.

Both Bhat's grandfathers were civil servants in Kashmir, men who were deeply connected to the people they represented, and Bhat says he can't reconcile himself with how disconnected the bureaucracy is today or how officials don't seem aware of basic environmental laws.

Another pet peeve about officials? Their written communication lacks dignity, often missing salutations or respectful words of address. In one analysis of around 300 RTI replies to citizens, Bhat found that in 99% of

cases, officials didn't address the applicants as 'Sir/Madam' or conclude with the standard 'Yours sincerely' sign-off. Even the younger lot who used the RTI and got justice in the earlier days, he says, haven't lived up to their promise. "I don't know what happens to them when they enter the bureaucracy," Bhat adds. "These things trouble me."

Mobilising support

In another lifetime, Bhat was a dentist who had patients from different regions of Kashmir. "Patients would tell me where they were from and I would write down the names of these faraway places. Then I started going there on my Yamaha motorcycle," he says. Curiosity drove him to move outwards right to the southwestern boundary of Budgam district that stretches up to the Pir Panjal mountains. "Now, there's no *tehsil* or block in the Valley where I don't have a contact," he says.

Most of Kashmir's NGT cases in the past six years have been filed by Bhat. While the orders often back him, enforcing them is the bigger challenge. He uses every trick in the book, from social media to local journalists. He mobilises citizens and phones or meets department heads incessantly. "I don't believe the narrative that nothing can be done any more," he says. "I get renewed energy from my victories. I feel like I have done something and that something is happening."



Priya Ramani is a Bengaluru-based journalist and the co-founder of India Love Project on Instagram.

GOREN BRIDGE

Play the percentages

East-West vulnerable. North deals

Bob Jones

South won the opening spade lead with his king and was very pleased with his contract. There were 11 easy tricks provided that the club suit came in for six tricks. That was a sure thing unless the missing clubs split 4-0, so South gave some thought about the best way to play the club suit. Knowing that West had long spades, South judged that East was far more likely to

have four clubs than West. Accordingly, South started clubs at trick two by leading a low club to dummy's ace. He was gob-smacked when East discarded a diamond! There was no longer any way to get to nine tricks. South cashed his eight top winners and settled for down one.

South could have done better. It would cost nothing to play the ace and queen of diamonds before starting on clubs. When West shows up with a singleton diamond, the

NORTH
♠ 10 9 7
♥ 7
♦ A K 2
♣ A Q 8 6 5 4

WEST
♠ A Q J 8 6 5
♥ K 9
♦ 5
♣ J 9 7 4

SOUTH
♠ K 4
♥ A J 10 3 2
♦ Q J 9
♣ K 10 2

The bidding:
NORTH 1♣ 2♣
EAST Pass Pass
SOUTH 1♥ 3NT
WEST 1♠ All pass

Opening lead: Queen of ♠

odds would change dramatically. It would be very unlikely that West held a club void in addition to a singleton diamond. South should then start clubs by cashing the king in his hand. When East shows

out, South will continue with the 10 of clubs and double finesse West out of the jack and nine of clubs, using the ace of hearts to re-enter his hand if West covers the 10 with the jack.

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What has June 7 ever given us?



The iconic Globe Theatre in London. (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

1 On June 7, 1195, Benedictine monk Gervase of Christ Church Cathedral Priory in Canterbury recorded an unusual event in his diary during a thunderstorm. He described 'a dense and dark cloud which grew into a spherical shape, from which a fiery globe fell towards the river'. This is the earliest known report of which rare atmospheric phenomenon?

2 On June 7, 1340, this place in the Netherlands was granted city rights. Its origins date back about 70 years earlier, when a dam was built across the River Rotte. Today, it is Europe's largest seaport, handling more than 450 million tonnes of cargo and connecting the Rhine to the North Sea. Which city is this?

3 On June 7, 1893, an Indian lawyer was forcibly removed from a first-class railway compartment at Pietermaritzburg, South Africa, while travelling to Pretoria. This incident prompted his first act of civil disobedience the next day. Who was this lawyer?

4 On June 7, 1917, Melvin Jones and a group of Chicago businessmen founded what would become the world's largest service club organisation. Guided by the motto 'We Serve', it now has more than a million members worldwide engaged in community service. Which organisation is this?

5 On June 7, 1924, George Mallory wrote a note indicating that he and Andrew 'Sandy' Irvine would begin a

historic quest the next day. Although Mallory's body was discovered many years later, it remains unknown whether they succeeded in completing it. Had he done so, Mallory would have become the first person to reach the summit of which mountain?

6 On June 7, 1929, the Lateran Treaty was ratified, leading to the establishment of an independent sovereign state. Which iconic city-state is this, and at just 44 hectares, the smallest country in the world?

7 On June 7, 1941, chemists Archer Martin and Richard Syngé gave the first demonstration of a method for separating the components of liquid mixtures. They were awarded the 1952 Nobel Prize in Chemistry for introducing the 'partition' form of

what is now a widely used analytical technique. What is the name of this process?

8 On June 7, 1979, ISRO successfully launched Bhaskara-I, an Earth-observation and meteorological satellite. It was India's first experimental remote-sensing satellite, placed in LEO, orbiting below 2,000 km height. What does the acronym LEO stand for?

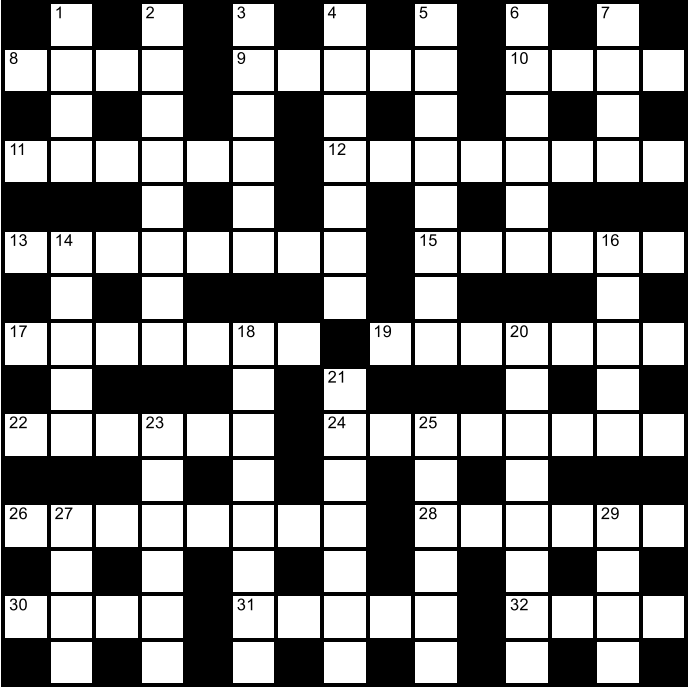
9 On June 7, 1982, this rock-and-roll star's former home in Memphis was opened to the public. Originally intended to help cover maintenance costs and taxes, it soon became one of the most visited private homes in the world. Which musician's residence, known as 'Graceland', is this?

10 On June 7, 2012, archaeologists unearthed the remains of a 16th-century theatre near a pub in Shoreditch, London. First opened in 1577, it was the home of the theatrical company Lord Chamberlain's Men. Which iconic playwright staged some of his earliest plays here before moving to the Globe Theatre?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

1. Baljit Singh
2. Rottend
3. M.K. Gandhi
4. Lions Club International
5. Mount Everest
6. Vatican City
7. Chronophotography
8. Low Earth Orbit
9. Elvis Presley
10. William Shakespeare

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 59 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
- 8 Power source in penitentiary (4)
9 Love chasm that is egg shaped (5)
10 Cry at sea, perhaps, in Idaho yacht (4)
11 Plane flying north carrying European (6)
12 Paddy, for example, for Hibernian (8)
13 At 10, Tod is confused... Look after... (6,2)
15 Bantu jumped around end of counter and produced headgear (6)
17 Drop down, from bus reversing, at bank (7)
19 In middle of spilled diesel, blockhead produces eats (7)
22 Excitedly praise Iran of yore (6)
24 A crime orchestrated by an inhabitant of the United States (8)
26 Mad red crane trapped (8)
28 Brags, "Starting to save in vessels" (6)
30 Nero fiddled in city (4)
31 Additional payment on us, boy, in the beginning (5)
32 Clock face laid back (4)

- Down**
- 1 Over-riding power to change vote (4)
2 Bank lets manufacture warm covers (8)
3 Robbed Theodore after John (6)
4 Head boy rejected can in back-room (7)
5 Acknowledged, "Matt died horribly" (8)
6 One accompanying Bolt is cleaner (6)

- 7 Adios! Leaving one and returning drink (4)
14 Correct about starting of ceasefire and suspension of hostilities (5)
16 Place to fight in region covering town at last (5)
18 Rant, "Aid biter? That's silly!" (8)
20 Bandits and groups capturing capital endlessly (8)
21 Young females... they may be bowled by bowlers (7)
23 One, sir, may be an aged person (6)
25 Stamp showing Bond's boss, I hear, with chief (6)
27 Unlock duck corral (4)
29 RIP... One may drop this on someone's death... (4)

SOLUTION NO. 58

S K N K B L S H
C H A M O M I L E S A M U S E
U N S T I S S P U L
L O G G E R S O C T O P U S
P A R T C I T A N D R U N
T O R S O H I T A N D R U N
O S T E A K
L E O N A R D O D A V I N C I
I N E B U L I S E R G A T E S
E I L I G A C T W
S U C C O U R A C T U A T E
M O C N A L I S A
E A R L Y C O M P O N E N T
N N X E S N S Y



Y. Mercy Famila
mercyfamila@gmail.com

“Does your husband help you in the kitchen?” “Do you help your wife in cooking?” If these common questions elicit “yes” as answer, the usual conclusion is that the man is progressive and affectionate towards his wife. But aren’t these questions laden with a deep gender bias?

In an interview with a celebrity couple on social media, the host asked the man if he helped his wife at home. Thousands have watched the interview, and liked, commented, and shared it. And many will wonder what is wrong with this long-time staple question. Pause and examine its structure carefully. The problem lies in the small word “help”. A person does not “help” in his own responsibilities. He discharges them on his own. But he helps in carrying out a responsibility of another person.

Such questions reveal deep-rooted gender discrimination. In one harmless-sounding question, society reveals its oldest belief that the kitchen belongs to women and men merely assist. It’s the hidden assumption. The word “help” becomes ideological, and such language normalises unequal domestic expectations. Serious attention should be paid to the politics of the word “help”. “Helping my wife” frames the husband as generous for doing the work that he should share equally.

Why are such questions always asked of a man? Is it not his responsibility to share work at home?

Questionable questions

Look at these socially accepted questions or remarks that betray emotional conditioning and carry patriarchal expectations: “Your husband helps you a lot at home, right?”; “You made your husband enter the kitchen?”; “You are lucky your husband helps you”; “Can your husband manage if you travel for work”; “Your husband allows you to work?”; “Why can’t she wake up early and cook before office?” The list is endless.

The questions are never innocent, and they carry an assumption which society considers normal. Inequality first appeared in language, and

THE SEMANTICS OF PATRIARCHY

How a certain language establishes domestic chores as the headache of only women

that is why changing society needs changing speech. Because the sentence that we casually repeat becomes part of the culture that we create.

The biggest tragedy which society fails to notice is that gender inequality is not in laws, restrictions, or visible oppressions. It survives through daily casual conversations, jokes, interview questions, advertisements, and comments in family gatherings. Patriarchy is part of the conversation, and hence difficult to detect.

A woman who returns home after working eight hours in office is asked, “What are you going to cook for dinner?” A man returns from office but is soothed by the question, “You must be tired?” The exhaustion of one is taken note of, while more work is expected from the other.

Consider how society speaks about fathers. When a mother looks after the baby, nobody applauds, but if a father changes the diaper, packs lunch for the child, or attends parent-teacher meetings, he becomes a “great dad”. Social media is flooded with admiration. Fathers are celebrated not for equal participation, but for temporary involvement.

Look at this advice often given to girls: “Learn cooking properly, it will help you after marriage.” At first glance, the sentence appears practical but underneath the advice exists a deep social malady. Cooking is not being taught as a life skill for men

and women , but as an essential skill for women for marriage. Kitchen is not a place that belongs to women alone. These questions silently perpetuate a patriarchy system in which men are supposed only to extend “help” to women.

Consider another familiar question asked of a working woman: “How do you manage both career and family?” Though this sounds like appreciation, this question is rarely posed to men. Balancing work and family is considered a woman’s special challenge and not a shared responsibility.

These days, women scale new heights and outshine men in many fields. But invisible biases appear on television, advertisements, and film. Men working in the kitchen are often shown as extraordinary, romantic or sheepish rather than as regular people. Children internalise these stereotypes and social approbations on who deserves authority, who deserves rest, and who should adjust. Gender equality is taught in schools, but is it practised? Perhaps, the most revolutionary thing to do today is to interrogate the everyday sentences that breed inequality.

Society disguises discrimination as normal conversation, humour, concern, advice, or curiosity. Today, discrimination survives not through open oppression but through normalised language. Gender bias today may not be found in explicit discrimination everywhere but it hides in casual conversation. That is what makes it more dangerous.

Every casual question carries a world view. Every repeated sentence silently teaches the next generation what is expected of women and what is excused for men.

The time has come for society to examine not only the answers but also the questions that are casually asked.

Misunderstood silence in classroom

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Schools are often celebrated as spaces where young minds are shaped, confidence is built, and every child is prepared for life. Yet, in almost every classroom, there exists one child who slowly fades into the background.

Not because they lack potential. Not because they do not understand. But because they are silent.

Silence is often misunderstood in classrooms. It is seen as a lack of confidence, a lack of knowledge, or sometimes even a lack of interest. But more often, it is simply a lack of space.

Every school event, morning assembly, cultural programme, or speech competition seems to revolve around the same set of children. The confident ones are chosen first. The naturally expressive are encouraged again and again. Meanwhile, the quieter students are left waiting, often without anyone even noticing. Over time, this silence is mistaken for inability.

What begins as a missed opportunity slowly turns into a pattern. The child who is never chosen begins to believe they are not meant to be chosen. The one who is never encouraged stops volunteering. The one who is constantly compared starts believing they are less than others. This is how invisibility is created.

And the most concerning part is how unnoticed this process is. It does not happen in a single moment.

It happens gradually, in small decisions, in repeated choices, in overlooked names. Teachers often wish to present their class as the best, and understandably so.

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We are but earth-bound creatures forever in thrall to time. We feel the rush of passing hours carrying us through life even as it drags us towards an inevitable end. The tide of time at its own pace – sometimes joyous, sometimes distressing, sometimes full of motion, sometimes hanging still – brooks no authority, has no master. Often, it can be a medley of voices mellifluous and raucous, solemn and vivacious with events that appear not in sequence but crowded together in chaotic confusion. We have no control over the ticking hands of time, and we mourn its unwitting loss. We have devised sundials, hourglasses, clocks, and watches to measure time, not stop it or hurry it. It is a way of trying to keep everything from happening at once.

Yet it is through this confusion of myriad experiences we have to pick our path and arrive at our conclusions, to walk forward through the crests and troughs with the faith that the highs and lows will pass. Aristotle regarded time as the measure of change, while Newton conceived of time as an absolute reality existing independently of change. Einstein’s theory of relativity reconciled aspects of both views by showing that time is neither wholly dependent on change nor absolutely independent of it; rather,

The ticking clock

The manner in which one spends time determines the future



its measurement depends on the observer’s motion and gravitational environment, making any single absolute definition of time impossible.

We turn to literature and agree with Shakespeare that the “inaudible and noiseless foot of time” creeps in on us and overtakes us in ways unknown. Dreams can crash, illusions may melt, disappointments can disappear, hopes can take shape. We are only processes, limited, finite in the infinite possibilities of life. Therefore, it is imperative we realise its

Time is a universal resource but there are times we are time-starved as priorities slip in the middle of competing demands

testing the atom bomb, was reminded of the dark message of Sri Krishna in the Gita: “I am the mighty Time, the source of destruction that comes forth to annihilate the worlds. Even without your participation, the warriors arrayed in the opposing army shall be destroyed.” Paradoxically time too is a healer, a force that brings truth and resilience, reconciliation and acceptance, allows wounds to heal and makes grief an awakening. To come back to the Bard, “How poor are they that have no patience, what wound did ever heal but by degrees?” The most tragic factor of time is its irreversibility, its refusal to roll back its trajectory in spite of entreaties. Time once lost cannot be retrieved leading to remorse.

Time is a universal resource we all have access to but there are times we are time-starved as priorities slip in the middle of competing demands. The manner in which we use our time determines our legacy, whether we lead a life by design or default.

Ecclesiastes 12:6-7 says, “The silver thread is broken, the gold lantern is shattered, the amphora at the fountain breaks, the bucket falls into the well, the earth returns to dust.” This talks of the fragility of last moments, urging us to remember the Creator before life ends, emphasising the need for spiritual awareness before the body gives up. Such then is the power of time. It is timeless.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

Amidst the many ongoing conflicts and crises, isn’t it beautiful to witness the world dividing into countless groups — not out of hatred or discord, but to cheer for and support their favourite teams in the FIFA World Cup? (‘In Kerala, the World Cup is personal’; May 31) In football, one may score any number of goals, but there is one common goal that all sports strive to achieve: fostering fraternity and camaraderie among people.

Jayasivakumar S.P.

India has never hosted the football world cup but one would hardly get that feeling in many parts of northern Kerala. There are fans galore mostly for Argentina and Brazil, but there are also supporters for teams like Puerto Rico and Cayman Islands. Kerala lives and breathes football.

T.S. Sanath Kumar

Behind the Nobel

Many Nobel laureates of Indian origin first imbibed the virtues of diligence, scholarship and intellectual ambition in India. (‘Whose brilliance is it anyway?’) Yet, the decisive alchemy that transformed promise into path-breaking achievement often occurred within the academic cultures and institutions of distant shores. Their triumphs thus embody a dual narrative — one of India’s prodigious human capital and another of opportunities relinquished.

Vijay Singh Adhikari

On the road

Travel paves the way for self-discovery. (‘What journeys can and cannot teach us’; May 31) Whether one travels out of necessity

or for pleasure, the traveller learns along the way. However, it is the sojourner’s reflective mindset that transforms a journey into an experience.

Praveen Kiran Martis

Why debate?

It is fascinating when, in this age of screens and digital isolation, a random person still initiates a conversation with a stranger. (‘Please leave me alone’; May 31) Such individuals have become a rare species, and their spontaneous acts of conversation have become equally rare.

S. Sundareswara Pandiyan

To spot total strangers and drag them into political discussions amounts to harassment. Such behaviour reflects a lack of civic sense and etiquette. It is time we got a crash course on how to behave in public places.

Samiul Hassan Quadri

Female friendships

Women often find strength, companionship and wisdom in one another’s company. (‘When a nun and a seer became friends’; May 31) In societies where a woman’s worth is frequently measured through her relationship with men, such stories offer a refreshing corrective.

Harsh Pawaria

Correction

In the ‘Easy like Sunday morning’ quiz on May 31, 2026, the year in which French minister Étienne de Silhouette imposed economic restrictions should have been 1759, and not as stated. The error is regretted.

— Editor



MORE ON THE WEB
www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

In defence of solitude

One does feel the need sometimes to distance oneself well away from others in order to take stock of life

George Netto

A linguistic buffet

When language changes with State boundaries

K.S. Venkatachalam

Thirukkural and modern medicine

For Thiruvalluvar, medicine is nothing but what we ingest as food

Rishi Kanna

Bus stops and milestones

A look at the lives that can’t help coming to the stops every day for meagre returns

Abhishek Bisht

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Akanksha Kamath

Have you heard of Pooja Tripathi? Unless you’ve been living under a rock, she is the Indian-American actor and writer behind *Brooklyn Coffee Shop*, the viral Instagram and YouTube sketch series that has turned the familiar ritual of ordering coffee into a weekly theatre of taste, status, self-delusion and moral collapses.

It’s 31 degrees in London when I speak to Tripathi, who is in Brooklyn, where the weather has also been behaving with similar dramatic flair. It’s the sort of small-talk opening that could, in another context, become the premise of an episode at the fictional Brooklyn café where she plays Thyme, a barista of immense disdain, alongside DJ Daughtry as Kale, her much taller, equally terrifying co-worker. Together, they serve customers who arrive bearing the spiritual baggage of modern city life, one absurd order at a time.

Brooklyn Coffee Shop is satire, certainly, but it is also one of the more persuasive arguments for the phone screen as a serious comic stage. Each episode of the series – which recently won the 2026 Webby Award in Video & Film, Comedy – runs for about a minute, but it has the rhythm of a sitcom, the texture

POOJA TRIPATHI. TOO COOL FOR COFFEE ORDERS

The actor-writer has turned the performative rituals of urban life into one of Instagram’s sharpest comedies with the Webby Award-winning *Brooklyn Coffee Shop*

of a meme and the polish of a small television production.

Genius of the judgy barista
Tripathi did not begin with a five-year plan or a studio strategy. Before the café became a proper production, she was making sketches alone on her phone, often using green screens, playing both the barista and the customer. When her first reel got over a few million views, a cinematographer friend suggested they shoot inside an actual café. The format had legs.

The genius of the café is that everyone already understands it. A customer walks in. Two baristas stand behind a counter. A transaction is expected. Instead, in *Brooklyn Coffee Shop*, a social

autopsy begins.

There is a reason these container formats work. *Chicken Shop Date*, the British YouTube show, turned writer-comedian Amelia Dimoldenberg’s deadpan celebrity interviews over fried chicken into a route to red carpets, including the Golden Globes and the Oscars. *Subway Takes*, Egyptian-American artist-comedian Kareem Rahma’s hot-take show filmed on the New York subway, has become a promotional stop for celebrities, politicians and public figures, while also expanding into longer-form YouTube formats. Their success has changed the old ladder and *Brooklyn Coffee Shop* belongs to that lineage.

“Ten years ago, having a TV show was kind of the only way you could

do something like this and get the reach. Then people started achieving reach online, but that was looked down on as content and not a TV show,” Tripathi explains. “But now, with what I’m doing, I started to realise, as we went along, that this is a very valid medium in and of itself.”

What *Brooklyn Coffee Shop* does differently though is to make it a scripted, character-led show that feels closer to a sitcom smuggled as a Reel into your feed, rather than an interview show. An “I am her, she is me” existential identification



(Clockwise from left) An episode of *Brooklyn Coffee Shop* being shot; Pooja Tripathi and DJ Daughtry on set; and the Indian-American actor and writer. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



unfurls as you watch someone spill the beans on their therapy sessions, or a tech-bro/angel investor who lost their job to the AI bot they created, come knocking for a barista job.

There is also something perfectly poetic about a South Asian girl playing a judgy eye-rolling barista. Tripathi is Indian-American. Daughtry is Black. Neither of them is the obvious Hollywood poster child for the hipster barista archetype. “If they were being cast by Hollywood, it’s very unlikely that they would choose an Indian girl and a Black man,” Tripathi says. “But because this is my project and because I’m writing it, I wanted to cast who I thought made sense to me. If the writing is good and the performances are good, people don’t question it. And then later, what it does is it expands your idea of what a person can be and who can play what kind of role without yelling it.”

Protective of her IP

The guest list is another reason to watch. Pakistani-American comedian and actor Kumail Nanjiani was in one, television host and author Padma Lakshmi has filmed an episode. As we speak, comedians Aziz Ansari, Hasan Minhaj, actors Priyanka Chopra, Jameela Jamil and author-entrepreneur Jay Shetty all come up as dream or potential guests. But Tripathi is not chasing celebrity for its own sake. What interests her is whether the person understands the world of the show and wants to play.

Of course, with great names comes great business. Although Tripathi is careful about how that business enters the frame. Brand deals help keep the whole thing self-funded, but she explains, “I’m pretty intense about the branding element. That’s how you maintain the trust and loyalty of an audience. If you don’t do that, people can tell you just did something

for money or validation.” So she only takes on brands that blend into the mundane and mad scenarios of the shop. She went to business school and worked in marketing before comedy, and dare I say, it’s the perfect trine.

Thinking beyond the show

As of publishing this piece, *Brooklyn Coffee Shop*’s YouTube Shorts routinely run into the hundreds of thousands, with some crossing the 10 million-view mark. “The lucky thing about social media is that the results are public. Once something starts moving, it becomes hard to argue with,” Tripathi says. The numbers have now become their own kind of calling card: nearly half a million followers for *Brooklyn Coffee Shop* on Instagram, and more than 260,000 on Tripathi’s personal account.

Tripathi is already thinking beyond the show. “I would love to create another series in the same way and keep expanding my skills as a writer,” she says.

Towards the end of our conversation, Tripathi tells me she may come to India next January for a wedding. Perhaps there could be a point in doing a watch party, she asks? “With a [panel] conversation leading into it, maybe?” I add. She is astonished that people in the country are watching. “The idea that where you end up is a place where people have also seen the show is pretty amazing,” she says.

The Internet has made everywhere feel closer, but *Brooklyn Coffee Shop* does something even sharper – it proves that a fictional café in Brooklyn can become a mirror for every city where people perform taste, politics, wellness and ambition in public. Somewhere behind that counter, an Indian-origin woman named Thyme is glaring at all of us, because we probably deserve it.

The writer is an independent journalist based in London, writing on fashion, luxury and lifestyle.



Sumana Mukherjee

At the bottom right corner of a large framed work in maroon and black, two letters stand out in their idiosyncrasy. ‘AL’, it reads a little shakily, the ‘A’ smaller than the ‘L’, every bit as individual as a signature. It recalls the way legendary 19th century weaver Dubraj Das finished his Baluchari saris by incorporating his name in the Bangla script. It is the only material proof modern-day textile historians have of this pathbreaking weaver’s work.

One can only guess at the prescience that led Das to mark his textiles for perpetuity, but it was hard convincing Anbulakshmi, the creator of the 57x29 inch work, to embroider her own initials as a final flourish for the piece. She had used symbols for sun rays (a radiating diamond form), buffalo horns, vultures (a decorative stacked ‘heart’) – all deeply embedded in the Toda vocabulary – and contemporary motifs. For



(L-R) Ramya Reddy; a richly embroidered shawl; Toda artisans at work; and the traditional technique. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

The Toda edit in Mumbai

40 art panels along with linens and saris from the hamlets of the Nilgiris will travel to the financial capital this week

millennia, across the world, women have toiled at work such as this, expecting no recognition or acknowledgement outside immediate circles of solidarity and companionship. To be encouraged to stamp their ownership on their creation is, frankly, an alien experience.

It is just one of the many struggles that Ramya Reddy, photographer-writer and founder of Coonoor & Co, a place-based textile and design practice rooted in the Nilgiris, has faced since launching the Toda Project, now 14 years old. “Last August, we showed a few of these pieces in Hyderabad. It was the first time my team saw their large work exhibited, and their response was one of awe,” says Reddy. “But it helped them appreciate why they had to sign

their work.” Their upcoming show in Mumbai will hopefully cement this.

With embroidery at its heart
Anbulakshmi’s frame, though immediately recognisable as Toda artistry in its use of colours, motifs and innate equilibrium, is distinct from the densely embroidered *puthukuzhy* (cloak) Reddy shows me at her Frazer Town studio in Bengaluru. Created by joining together two pitloom-woven strips of *kora* cloth and richly embroidered in the traditional Toda colours – with the heavier work designed to cover the front of the body when draped toga style – the cloak is, in a way, Reddy’s inheritance. It was bequeathed to her by Mutsin, a matriarch of the Melgaar clan, who took Reddy

under her wing when she was working on her book *Soul of the Nilgiris* (2018).

Conceptualised as a visuals-led documentation of the indigenous communities and ecology of the Nilgiris after Reddy graduated in photography from Light & Life Academy in Udhagamandalam, the book paved the way to a greater engagement with the Toda people in unforeseen ways. “I wanted the spine of the book to carry Toda handwork,” says Reddy. “As Mutsin and her daughter-in-law Seetha helped me commission and collect 2,000 such pieces, they shared their vision for their embroidery.”

It lay far beyond the touristy trinkets sold as Toda mementoes in the markets of Udhagamandalam and Coonoor. In a story only too familiar in India’s craft sector, a lack

of knowledge of, and respect for, lesser-known handmade traditions had triggered a vicious cycle: buyers refusing to pay for quality handwork which led to cotton threads being swapped for acrylic and substandard embroidery trumping labour-intensive versions to meet expected price points.

Determined to take their legacy forward, Mutsin and Seetha helped Reddy grow her team of textile artists to a healthy 70 today. Reddy, on her part, has contributed to the growth by donning many hats: businesswoman, designer, facilitator, outreach, social media photographer. The last causes her some angst, as it is often the only ongoing expression of her original passion.

But, as she travels through the Nilgiris, visiting the far-flung hamlets where her artists/artisans live, she is rarely without her preferred Sony Alpha a7 iii or Fuji X T5 cameras. While the Todas have been subject to multiple academic lenses over the past century, their declining numbers – less than 1,500 today – and movement away from

age-old cultural practices make all documentation critical.

Big city showing

It is partly in this spirit that Reddy ensures the Toda work travels out of the Nilgiris. Besides Hyderabad, her team showed at the just concluded Kochi-Muziris Biennale. But the upcoming Mumbai show is her biggest one yet, and not only by way of the large-format artworks and gorgeous linen, cotton, cotton-merino, khadi saris – some of them blockprinted in Jaipur with the Nilgiris’ own flora, such as the *kurinji*, rhododendron and magnolia – that will be up for display and sale.

“Southern India is somewhat familiar with the Todas but the further north you go, the lower the awareness,” she says. “Mumbai is the right city to platform the project at this point.” As has been her practice, Reddy will be travelling with two senior and one junior artisan to present their work at the 47-A gallery and run workshops and demos. Coonoor & Co is also in talks with Selvedge, the U.K.-based textile-focused multimedia platform, to participate in the inaugural edition of London Textile Month, which runs through September.

Showing at 47-A, Khotachiwadi, June 12-28. Textiles range between ₹2,500 and ₹27,000, and artworks are priced upwards of ₹20,000.

The writer and editor is based in Bengaluru.